On the international front, we had gone back to the bargaining table with the Russians to begin the process of reducing the threat of nuclear war while also beginning the first comprehensive modernization of our strategic and conventional forces in twenty years. By making a military career more attractive, we had begun to draw more of the best and brightest of our young people into the voluntary military forces.

And I think the nation had begun the process of spiritual revival that was so badly needed. It was once again striving to live up to that special vision of America expressed more than three hundred years ago by John Winthrop on the deck of a tiny vessel off the coast of Massachusetts, when he told the pilgrims gathered with him on the edge of the New World that they had the opportunity to create a new civilization based on freedom unlike any other before it, a unique and special “shining city on a hill.”

But for all our progress, there was much left to be done.

We were plunging deeper into the nation’s worst recession since the 1930s, and the world was still a very dangerous place. Leonid Brezhnev had rebuffed my expressions of hope for a warmer relationship between our countries. In the Middle East, dangerous embers of malevolence and hatred smoldering since biblical times had erupted into savage warfare. In Afghanistan, the Soviets were attempting to subdue winds of freedom with a ruthlessness bordering on barbarity, and in Poland their puppet government was preparing to impose martial law to suppress a growing trade union movement. In a cynical rejection of basic human rights, Soviet leaders, some of them motivated by the same anti-Semitism seen in the murderous Russian pogroms of the past, held thousands of Jews captive, refusing to let them emigrate. And every day there was more evidence that Fidel Castro, the proxy of Moscow, was shipping more arms and Communist “advisors” into Central America, and